the Kashmir 'struggle' rather than being sponsored by either the *Hizb-e-Islami* or the *Jamiat-e-Islami*. As the then EAM Dinesh Singh, defending the government's conciliatory approach towards Afghanistan, explained to his parliamentary colleagues, New Delhi was aware that Pakistan has arranged training facilities for Kashmiri militants in locations within Afghanistan. However, it firmly believed in Kabul's assurances that the Afghan government was not involved in any assistance being provided to Kashmiri militants.[101] In reality, the bigger worry from Afghanistan was not the intrusions in Kashmir, but the influx of Afghan refugees in light of the ongoing civil war. Starting with approximately 15,860 in April–May 1992, the number rose to 18,139 by February 1993, and 24,662 by May 1995 (and eventually reached 60,000 by 2011).[102] Either the Indian government would need to provide for them, or ensure their safe return with help from the Mujahideen government. Though most of such Afghans stayed back in India, the Rao government was keen on the latter option.

Taliban dilemma

On 16 May 1996, Narasimha Rao stepped down as PM of India, and on 25 September 1996, Kabul fell to the Taliban. The two events, though unrelated, changed the course of India's Afghanistan policy once again. Rao's departure meant a key conciliator was out of office, and the Taliban's ascendance meant that Pakistan's influence in Afghanistan had increased manifold. That New Delhi had taken few operational measures to counter the Taliban's rise at the outset, underlined India's post-Cold War foreign policy flux. Despite knowing that the strategic border post of Spin Boldak in Kandahar had fallen to a new militia called the Taliban in October 1994, that the Pakistani army had provided heavy artillery cover fire for the same, India did little to safeguard its interests.[103] Both the MEA and R&AW wrote the Taliban off as another Pakistan-supported fringe militia.[104] The Taliban's existence only corroborated Indian advocacy of Pakistan's interference in Afghan domestic affairs. In fact, whatever intelligence India received about the intricacies of the Taliban in 1994–95, ironically, came from Massoud, who had opened a channel with the Taliban (to defeat Hekmatyar). Bhadrakumar had undertaken a mission to Kabul in the winter of 1994 to engage